

Question 28 · Unit 2 · 8 Marks

Explain the need for integrating HRD practices with organisational strategy.

Introduction

Strategy is the organisation's chosen path to its goals — which products, which customers, what quality, what technology, what cost. HRD practices build the people who must walk that path. Integration means HRD questions are asked in the same breath as strategy questions: if we want X in three years, what must our people be able to do, and how will we develop that?

Need means why this integration is necessary, not merely 'it is good'. Unconnected HRD can be busy, popular and still useless to the organisation.

Detailed points

- 1. Strategy is implemented by people, not by slides.** A board decision to digitalise branches, enter a new state, or raise quality will fail if staff cannot use systems, sell the new offer, or lead the new teams. Capability is strategy execution. That is the first need for integration.
- 2. Avoid irrelevant and wasteful training.** Without strategy, the calendar fills with fashionable topics. Budget and employee time are limited. Integration is needed as a filter: what not to train. Opportunity cost is a real need in poor and mid-sized firms as well as large ones.
- 3. Talent must be ready in time.** Strategy may need twenty new team leaders in two years. Career and potential systems must start now. You cannot hire overnight always; internal development takes time. Integration is about calendar of people, not only calendar of courses.
- 4. Different strategies need different climates.** A cost-leadership strategy needs discipline and waste control. An innovation strategy needs psychological safety to try and fail. HRD climate work must match the strategy type. Integration is cultural, not only technical.
- 5. Change and resistance.** Strategic change frightens people. Integrated HRD (communication, reskilling, counselling) reduces resistance. If HRD is not in the change plan, the strategy remains a circular.
- 6. Credibility and survival of the HRD function.** When HRD can show contribution to strategic outcomes, it is funded. When it cannot, it is the first budget cut. Integration is needed for HRD's own effectiveness and status — which then helps employees, because an unfunded HRD cannot develop them.
- 7. Meaning and motivation for employees.** People learn better when they see why. 'We are learning this because we are opening rural branches next year' is more motivating than 'please attend'. Integration gives meaning, which supports transfer.
- 8. What integration looks like in practice (to complete the need).** Competency maps from strategy; TNA against those maps; IDPs reviewed in business meetings; succession for strategic roles; stopping obsolete courses. Need is not abstract — it shows up as these habits.

Conclusion. *Integration is needed because people execute strategy, resources are scarce, talent takes time, climate must match strategy, change must be supported, HRD must stay credible, and employees need meaning. Unintegrated HRD is activity without impact on organisational goals.*